

Everyday English LN905

Contents

Lesson 1: Small Talk in Britain

Lesson 2: Navigating Social Situations in the UK

Lesson 3: Everyday English — Food in the UK

Lesson 4: Everyday English for Discussing Current Affairs

Lesson 1: Small Talk in Britain

Background: Why Small Talk Matters in Britain

Small talk — brief, informal conversation about unimportant topics — plays a central role in British social life. Far from being meaningless, it serves as a social lubricant: it signals friendliness, establishes rapport, and helps people feel comfortable before discussing more serious matters. A British person who skips small talk and launches straight into business may be perceived as rude or abrupt.

The weather is the most iconic topic for British small talk, but queues, public transport, sport, and weekend plans are all common. Understanding the unwritten rules of small talk is a key step in integrating successfully into British academic and professional environments.

Open with Something Low-Stakes

The goal of an opener is just to start the conversation, not to be clever. Simple observations work perfectly.

- *"Have you been here before?"*
- *"How do you know [the host/organizer]?"*
- *"That was a great presentation — did you have a chance to catch it?"*
- *"How's your week been so far?"*

Avoid yes/no questions when you can — they make the conversation die quickly.

The Core Strategy: Ask, Listen, Share

Good small talk has a rhythm. **Ask** a question, **listen** genuinely, then **share** something related about yourself before asking a follow-up. This keeps it from feeling like an interview and creates a natural back-and-forth.

"Where are you from originally?" → They answer → *"Oh interesting, I've always wanted to visit. I'm from Chicago myself — have you ever been?"*

Finding Common Ground

People open up when they feel you're on the same wavelength. A few tactics:

- **Mirror their energy.** If they're relaxed, be relaxed. If they're enthusiastic, match it.
- **Use "me too" moments.** When they mention something you relate to, say so — it builds instant rapport.
- **Find the thread.** If someone mentions their job, ask what they like about it rather than just what they do. It leads to richer conversation.

Keep It Moving with Follow-Up Questions

The most important skill in small talk is the follow-up. When someone says something, don't just nod — dig one layer deeper.

- *"That's interesting — what got you into that?"*
- *"How long have you been doing that?"*
- *"What's that been like?"*
- *"What do you enjoy most about it?"*

The acronym **FORD** is a classic cheat sheet for safe, reliable topics: **Family, Occupation, Recreation, Dreams.**

Graceful Transitions and Exits

Knowing how to shift or end a conversation is just as important as starting one.

To transition to someone new:

- *"It was so great chatting with you — I'm going to go grab a drink, but let's catch up more later."*
- *"I should go say hi to a few people, but I really enjoyed this."*

To change the subject:

- *"That reminds me actually..." or "On a totally different note..."*

A Few Golden Rules

- **Be curious, not performative.** People can tell the difference between genuine interest and going through the motions. Ask things you actually want to know.
- **Use their name.** Dropping someone's name once or twice in a conversation makes them feel seen.
- **Give compliments that invite conversation.** Instead of *"I like your bag,"* try *"I love that bag — where did you find it?"*
- **It's okay to be a little vulnerable.** Admitting *"I'm terrible at these events, honestly"* is disarming and relatable — most people feel the same way.
- **Let silences breathe.** Not every pause needs to be filled. A calm, comfortable silence can actually signal confidence.

Interrupting a Conversation

Sometimes you need to jump in — whether to add a point, redirect things, or get someone's attention. The key is to acknowledge you're cutting in so it doesn't feel rude.

Polite entry points:

- *"Sorry to jump in, but..."*
- *"Can I add something to that?"*
- *"I don't mean to interrupt, but I just wanted to say..."*
- *"Before we move on — I have to mention..."*
- *"Piggybacking on what you just said..."*

When joining a group mid-conversation:

- *"Mind if I join you?"*
- *"I couldn't help but overhear — I hope it's okay to chime in..."*
- *"I was just walking by and caught that — I actually have some thoughts on it if you don't mind."*

When you need to get someone's attention one-on-one:

- *"Hey, I don't want to interrupt, but do you have a quick second?"*
- *"Whenever there's a break, I'd love to grab you for a moment."*

Leaving a Conversation

Exits are an art. You want to leave warmly without it feeling abrupt or like you're escaping.

Classic, all-purpose exits:

- *"It was so great talking with you — I'm going to go mingle a little, but let's catch up more soon."*
- *"I'll let you get back to it, but I really enjoyed this."*
- *"I need to go say hello to a few people, but this was genuinely fun."*
- *"I don't want to monopolize your time — it was wonderful chatting."*

Using a natural excuse:

- *"I'm going to grab another drink — can I get you anything?"* (whether or not you come back is up to you)
- *"I promised myself I'd introduce myself to a few new people tonight, so I'm going to go do that."*
- *"I should go find [name] before it gets too crowded in here."*

Ending with something that makes the other person feel good:

- *"I'm really glad we got to talk — I feel like I could have kept going for another hour."*
- *"You've given me a lot to think about — seriously."*
- *"I hope we run into each other again."*

Part I – Vocabulary

Key Expressions

Study the following expressions and example sentences.

Expression / Word	Meaning / Usage
<i>Lovely weather, isn't it?</i>	A classic British opener. 'Tag questions' (isn't it? aren't they?) invite agreement and keep conversation flowing.
<i>Not bad for this time of year.</i>	A typically understated British response — neither fully positive nor negative.
<i>Dreadful out there, isn't it?</i>	Complaining about bad weather is perfectly acceptable and creates solidarity.
<i>Fancy seeing you here!</i>	An expression of (genuine or mock) surprise at meeting someone.
<i>How are you getting on?</i>	A friendly enquiry about how someone is managing; slightly more personal than 'How are you?'
<i>Not too bad, thanks. You?</i>	A non-committal, polite response. Bouncing the question back is expected.
<i>I must say, the queue is moving quickly today.</i>	Using an observation to start conversation in a shared space (e.g. a supermarket).
<i>Did you catch the match last night?</i>	Asking about sport — a very common small-talk topic among British people.

What are you up to this weekend?	A casual enquiry about plans; common on Friday afternoons.
Anyway, I'd better let you get on.	A polite way to end a conversation without causing offence.
It's been lovely chatting.	A warm closing expression before parting ways.
Cheers!	Informal: thank you / goodbye. Widely used across the UK.

Part 2 – Comprehension Task

Activity A: True or False

Read the statements below and decide whether they are True (T) or False (F) based on the Background section and vocabulary above. Write T or F in the space provided.

1. 1. ____ In Britain, it is considered rude to talk about the weather.
2. 2. ____ 'Not too bad' is a typically British understated response to mean things are going reasonably well.
3. 3. ____ Small talk is only used in professional settings, not in social ones.
4. 4. ____ A tag question such as 'isn't it?' is used to invite agreement and keep the conversation going.
5. 5. ____ 'Anyway, I'd better let you get on' is used to open a conversation.
6. 6. ____ 'Cheers' can mean both 'thank you' and 'goodbye' in British informal English.

Part 3 – Gap-Fill Task

Activity B: Complete the Conversations

Fill each gap with an appropriate expression from the vocabulary box. Use each expression once.

Word box: Fancy seeing you here! / Did you catch the match last night? / Not bad for this time of year. / What are you up to this weekend? / It's been lovely chatting. / Anyway, I'd better let you get on.

7. 1. A: 'The sun's actually out today!' B: 'Yes, _____!'
8. 2. A: 'England were brilliant in the first half.' B: 'I know! _____ It was incredible.'
9. 3. A: '_____ Anna! I didn't know you shopped here.'
10. 4. A: '_____ Any nice plans?' B: 'Just visiting family, I think.'
11. 5. A: '_____ I need to catch my bus.' B: 'Of course! Take care!'
12. 6. A: 'Same time next week then?' B: 'Absolutely. _____'

Part 4 – Language Focus: Understatement

Activity C: Matching

British small talk often involves understatement — saying less than you mean to appear modest or polite. Match each understated expression (1–5) with its likely true meaning (a–e).

13. 1. 'It's not exactly warm today, is it?'
14. 2. 'The queue's not moving terribly fast.'
15. 3. 'He's not the most talkative person.'
16. 4. 'It was quite a good result, I suppose.'
17. 5. 'I'm not sure the trains have been great this week.'

- a. The trains have been terrible this week.
- b. It is absolutely freezing.
- c. He barely speaks.
- d. The queue is moving very slowly.
- e. It was an excellent result.

Part 5 – Speaking Task

Activity D: Role Play

Work in pairs. Choose one of the scenarios below and conduct a small-talk conversation of approximately 2 minutes. Use at least four expressions from the vocabulary list. Then swap roles and try a different scenario.

Scenario 1: At the bus stop

Student A: You are waiting for a bus that is 15 minutes late. Start a conversation with the stranger next to you.

Student B: Respond naturally and keep the conversation going for at least three exchanges.

Scenario 2: In the university common room on a Friday

Student A: It is the end of the week. You recognise a classmate you don't know well. Start a

conversation.

Student B: Respond and ask at least one follow-up question before closing the conversation politely.

ANSWER KEY

Activity A: True or False

Item	Answer
1	F — Talking about the weather is extremely common and acceptable in Britain.
2	T
3	F — Small talk is used in both social and professional settings.
4	T
5	F — It is used to close a conversation.
6	T

Activity B: Gap-Fill

Item	Answer
1	Not bad for this time of year.
2	Did you catch the match last night?
3	Fancy seeing you here!
4	What are you up to this weekend?
5	Anyway, I'd better let you get on.
6	It's been lovely chatting.

Activity C: Matching

Item	Answer
1	b — It is absolutely freezing.
2	d — The queue is moving very slowly.
3	c — He barely speaks.
4	e — It was an excellent result.
5	a — The trains have been terrible this week.

Lesson 2: Navigating Social Situations in the UK

Background: Social Rules and Indirect Communication

The UK has a distinct communication style that can be puzzling for international students. British people tend to avoid direct confrontation and favour indirect, polite language. Saying 'no' bluntly is rare; instead, you are more likely to hear softened refusals, vague apologies, or hedged requests.

Other important social norms include: respecting personal space, queuing (waiting in line) without pushing, and saying 'sorry' even when you are not at fault — for example, if someone bumps into you. Mastering these conventions will help you feel more confident in a British social environment.

Part I – Vocabulary Input

Key Expressions

Expression / Word	Meaning / Usage
<i>I'm so sorry, I didn't mean to —</i>	An immediate, automatic apology for a minor accident. British people apologise very frequently.
<i>No worries / Not at all.</i>	A reassuring response to an apology, meaning 'it doesn't matter'.
<i>Would you mind...?</i>	A very polite way to make a request. Always followed by -ing. (e.g. 'Would you mind moving your bag?')
<i>Could I possibly...?</i>	A formal, polite request. 'Possibly' softens it further.
<i>I was wondering if you could...</i>	An indirect way to ask for a favour; less direct than 'Can you...?'
<i>I'm afraid I can't make it.</i>	A polite way to decline an invitation. 'I'm afraid' softens disappointing news.
<i>That's a shame / What a pity.</i>	A sympathetic response to bad news. Not overly emotional — politely empathetic.
<i>After you.</i>	Said when letting someone go first (through a door, etc.) — a gesture of politeness.
<i>Do you mind if I...?</i>	Asking permission politely. (e.g. 'Do you mind if I sit here?')
<i>I don't mean to be a bother, but...</i>	A softener before making a request or raising a problem.
<i>It's not quite what I was expecting.</i>	An indirect way to express dissatisfaction without being confrontational.
<i>Excuse me — sorry to interrupt, but...</i>	Used to attract attention or interrupt without causing offence.

Part 2 – Multiple Choice

Activity A: Choose the Most Appropriate Response

Circle the letter of the most socially appropriate response for each situation.

18. 1. You accidentally bump into someone in a corridor.
- A. 'Watch where you're going!'
 - B. 'Oh, I'm so sorry, I didn't mean to!'
 - C. 'It's fine.'
19. 2. A classmate invites you to a party but you cannot come.
- A. 'No, I'm busy.'
 - B. 'That sounds rubbish.'
 - C. 'Oh, I'm afraid I can't make it — I've got a prior commitment. What a shame!'
20. 3. You want someone to move their bag from a seat on the train.
- A. 'Move your bag.'
 - B. 'Would you mind moving your bag? I'd like to sit down.'
 - C. 'Your bag is on the seat.'
21. 4. You arrive late to a meeting and want to take a seat without disrupting others.
- A. You walk in loudly and explain yourself at length.
 - B. You say 'Excuse me — sorry to interrupt' and quietly take a seat.
 - C. You say nothing and sit down heavily.
22. 5. A friend shows you a cake they baked. It tastes dry, but you don't want to hurt their feelings.
- A. 'This is very dry and not very nice.'
 - B. 'I love the decoration! The texture is... interesting.'
 - C. 'It's not quite what I was expecting, but the effort shows!'

Part 3 – Error Correction

Activity B: Rewrite for Politeness

The sentences below are too direct for British social contexts. Rewrite each one using appropriate language from the vocabulary list. The first one is done as an example.

Example: 'Give me a pen.' → 'I was wondering if you could lend me a pen?'

23. 1. 'Move out of the way.' → _____
24. 2. 'I can't come to your dinner.' → _____
25. 3. 'Can I sit here?' → _____
26. 4. 'The service here is very slow.' → _____

27. 5. 'Help me carry this.' → _____

Part 4 – Reading and Response

Activity C: Understand the Subtext

In British culture, what people say is not always what they mean. Read each statement and write what the speaker is likely thinking.

28. 1. A colleague says: 'That's one way of doing it.' → They probably mean:

29. 2. Your host says: 'I'm sure you won't want another piece of cake.' → They probably mean:

30. 3. A tutor says: 'This is quite an interesting approach.' → They probably mean:

31. 4. Someone at a party says: 'We must do this again sometime!' → They probably mean:

32. 5. A friend says: 'No, no, don't worry about me!' → They probably mean:

Part 5 – Speaking Task

Activity D: Role Play

Work in pairs. Act out the following situations using appropriate vocabulary from this lesson.

Situation 1: In the library

Student A: You need to ask the person next to you to turn their music down (they have headphones but the sound is leaking). Be polite.

Student B: Respond politely. Apologise and agree to turn it down.

Situation 2: At a friend's flat

Student A: Your friend has cooked a meal that is over-spiced. Use indirect language to let them know without causing offence.

Student B: Listen, respond politely, and offer to adjust the meal if possible.

ANSWER KEY

Activity A: Multiple Choice

Item	Answer
1	B — Immediate apology is the expected British response.
2	C — Soft refusal with 'I'm afraid', a reason, and empathy ('What a shame!').
3	B — Polite request with 'Would you mind...?'
4	B — Quiet entry with a brief 'Excuse me — sorry to interrupt'.
5	C — Indirect dissatisfaction; acknowledges effort without praising the taste.

Activity B: Rewrite for Politeness (suggested answers — accept reasonable variations)

Item	Answer
1	'Excuse me — would you mind stepping aside?'
2	'I'm afraid I can't make it to your dinner. What a shame!'
3	'Do you mind if I sit here?'
4	'I don't mean to be a bother, but the service has been rather slow today.'
5	'I was wondering if you could help me carry this?'

Activity C: Understand the Subtext

Item	Answer
1	They think it is the wrong or a poor way of doing it.
2	They are actually offering more cake and expecting the guest to take a piece.
3	The tutor thinks the approach is unusual or possibly incorrect, but is being diplomatic.
4	This is often a polite social nicety with no firm intention — they may not plan to meet again.
5	They probably do want to be included or would like the offer to be made again.

Lesson 3: Everyday English — Food in the UK

Background: Food Culture in the UK

British food culture has changed dramatically in recent decades. Alongside traditional staples such as fish and chips, a full English breakfast, and Sunday roast, modern British food is enormously diverse, reflecting waves of immigration and globalisation. Curry is often cited as Britain's most popular dish, and supermarkets stock ingredients from across the world.

Key food-related contexts for international students include: shopping at a supermarket or market, ordering in a café or restaurant, discussing dietary requirements, and socialising over meals. Understanding the language used in these settings is essential for everyday life in the UK.

Part I – Vocabulary Input

Section A: Food and Meals

Expression / Word	Meaning / Usage
a full English (breakfast)	A cooked breakfast typically including eggs, bacon, sausages, toast, baked beans, mushrooms, and tomatoes.
a Sunday roast	A traditional British meal served on Sundays: roasted meat (chicken, beef, or lamb), roast potatoes, vegetables, Yorkshire pudding, and gravy.
a takeaway	Food ordered from a restaurant and eaten at home; also the restaurant itself. (US: 'takeout')
a packed lunch	A meal prepared at home and taken to school, university, or work (usually in a box or bag).
mains / starters / desserts	The three courses of a restaurant meal: first course (starter), main course, and sweet course (dessert).
to be peckish	Informal: to feel slightly hungry. ('I'm a bit peckish — shall we grab a snack?')
to grab a bite	Informal: to eat a quick, casual meal. ('I need to grab a bite before my lecture.')

Section B: Shopping and Cooking

Expression / Word	Meaning / Usage
the weekly shop	The main supermarket visit of the week to buy groceries.
on offer	Reduced in price; on sale. ('The pasta is on offer this week — two for one.')
sell-by / use-by date	The date printed on food packaging. 'Sell-by' tells the shop; 'use-by' is the safety deadline.

free-range	Describes eggs or meat from animals raised with outdoor access, seen as more ethical.
to be a fussy eater	To be someone who dislikes many foods and is difficult to cook for.
gluten-free / dairy-free	Food made without gluten (for those with coeliac disease) or dairy products (for vegans or those with intolerances).
to season to taste	To add salt, pepper, or other seasonings according to your own preference.

Section C: In a Café or Restaurant

Expression / Word	Meaning / Usage
Are you ready to order?	What a waiter asks when they come to take your food or drink order.
I'll have... / Could I have...?	Ways to place an order politely. 'I'll have the soup, please.'
Could we get the bill, please?	How to ask for the bill at the end of a meal. (US: 'check')
Is service included?	Asking whether a tip is already added to the bill.
medium rare / well done	How you would like steak cooked. Medium rare = pink inside; well done = cooked through.
a flat white / an Americano	Popular coffee types in UK cafés. Flat white: espresso with steamed milk; Americano: espresso with hot water.
Any allergies?	A common question from waiting staff. Be ready to communicate dietary needs clearly.

Part 2 – Vocabulary Matching

Activity A: Match the Word to the Definition

Draw a line to match each word or phrase (1–8) with its correct definition (a–h).

33. 1. a takeaway
34. 2. peckish
35. 3. use-by date
36. 4. a Sunday roast
37. 5. on offer
38. 6. free-range
39. 7. a packed lunch
40. 8. to season to taste

- a. A meal with roasted meat and vegetables, eaten on Sundays.

- b. From animals that were raised with outdoor access.
- c. The last safe date to eat a food product.
- d. Food ordered to eat at home.
- e. A meal prepared at home and brought to work or school.
- f. Slightly hungry.
- g. Add salt and pepper according to your own preference.
- h. Reduced in price temporarily.

Part 3 – Gap-Fill

Activity B: Complete the Conversations

Fill each gap using a word or phrase from the vocabulary lists above.

41. 1. Waiter: 'Are you ready to order?' Student: '_____, the mushroom risotto, please.'
42. 2. A: 'I'm starving!' B: 'Me too — let's _____ before the lecture.'
43. 3. A: 'Is this chicken OK to eat?' B: 'Check the _____. It says tomorrow, so it's fine.'
44. 4. A: 'Do you want to cook tonight?' B: 'Actually, shall we just get a _____? I fancy a curry.'
45. 5. A: 'The pasta is _____ this week — 50p off.' B: 'Great, let's get two.'
46. 6. Waiter: 'How would you like your steak?' Customer: '_____, please — just a little pink.'
47. 7. A: 'Can you eat anything?' B: 'Not really — I'm a _____ and I don't eat fish or mushrooms.'
48. 8. A: 'Should we ask for the _____?' B: 'Yes — could we get the bill, please?'

Part 4 – Writing Task

Activity C: Write a Café Order

Imagine you are in a British café. Write a short dialogue (6–8 lines) between you and the waiter. Include:

- Ordering a drink (use a coffee type from the vocabulary)
- Ordering food (use the structure 'I'll have...' or 'Could I have...?')
- Asking about allergens
- Asking for the bill at the end

Your dialogue:

Waiter: _____

You: _____

Waiter: _____

You: _____

Waiter: _____

You: _____

Waiter: _____

You: _____

Part 5 – Discussion

Activity D: Food in My Country and the UK

Discuss the following questions in small groups. Use vocabulary from this lesson where possible.

49. 1. What do you typically eat for breakfast in your country? How does it compare to a 'full English'?
50. 2. What food do you miss most from home? Have you been able to find it in the UK?
51. 3. Have you tried any traditional British dishes? What did you think?
52. 4. What are the biggest differences between shopping for food in your country and in the UK?
53. 5. Are you a fussy eater? Do you have any dietary requirements?

ANSWER KEY

Activity A: Matching

Item	Answer
1	d — Food ordered to eat at home.
2	f — Slightly hungry.
3	c — The last safe date to eat a food product.
4	a — A meal with roasted meat and vegetables, eaten on Sundays.
5	h — Reduced in price temporarily.
6	b — From animals that were raised with outdoor access.
7	e — A meal prepared at home and brought to work or school.
8	g — Add salt and pepper according to your own preference.

Activity B: Gap-Fill

Item	Answer
1	I'll have / Could I have
2	grab a bite
3	use-by date
4	takeaway
5	on offer
6	Medium rare
7	fussy eater
8	bill

Activity C: Model Dialogue

Waiter: Good morning! Are you ready to order?
You: Could I have a flat white, please?
Waiter: Of course. And to eat?
You: I'll have the avocado toast, please. Does it contain any dairy?
Waiter: No, it's completely dairy-free.
You: Perfect, thank you.

(Later...)

You: Could we get the bill, please?

Waiter: Of course. Is service included? Yes — it's already added.

Note: Accept any reasonable dialogue that includes the four required elements.

Lesson 4: Everyday English for Discussing Current Affairs

Background: Talking About the News in Britain

Engaging with current affairs is an important skill for students in British universities. Tutors and classmates often reference news events in seminars and casual conversation, and the ability to discuss these topics confidently — agreeing, disagreeing, and qualifying opinions — is essential for academic success and social integration.

In Britain, it is generally considered polite to express opinions cautiously, using hedging language ('I think...', 'It seems to me...') rather than stating things too bluntly. However, lively debate is welcomed in academic settings, and students are expected to support opinions with reasoning.

Part I – Vocabulary Input

Section A: News and Media

Expression / Word	Meaning / Usage
current affairs	Events happening now, especially in politics and public life. ('I try to keep up with current affairs.')
a headline	The title of a news story. Often uses dramatic or compressed language.
to go viral	Informal: when a video, story, or post spreads rapidly online and gets millions of views.
breaking news	An important story that is happening right now and being reported as it unfolds.
the mainstream media	Large, widely distributed news outlets (BBC, newspapers). Often contrasted with social media.
bias / biased	Unfair preference for one side. 'This article seems biased towards the government.'
to be well-informed	To have a good understanding of current events. ('You should try to be well-informed before the debate.')

Section B: Opinion Language

Expression / Word	Meaning / Usage
In my view / In my opinion...	Used to introduce a personal opinion clearly. More formal than 'I think'.
It seems to me that...	A hedged way to introduce an opinion, suggesting it may not be universally agreed.
I'd argue that...	Slightly more assertive — used to advance an argument, common

	in academic discussion.
That said, ...	Used to introduce a contrasting point. ('It was a good speech. That said, the policy is flawed.'))
To a certain extent...	Used to partially agree with something. ('To a certain extent, the report is accurate.')
I take your point, but...	Acknowledges someone's argument before introducing a counter-argument.
It's a complex issue.	Used to show awareness that a topic has multiple sides; avoids oversimplification.
I'm not sure I agree entirely.	A polite, hedged way to disagree without being confrontational.

Section C: Discussing Change and Impact

Expression / Word	Meaning / Usage
to have a significant impact on	To affect something considerably. ('Social media has had a significant impact on politics.')
in the short / long term	Describing effects that are immediate vs those that develop over time.
widespread concern / support	Concern or support felt across a large group of people. ('There is widespread concern about housing costs.')
to be at the heart of the debate	To be the central issue being argued about.
to call for reform	To demand or request a change in law or policy.
to raise awareness (of)	To make more people conscious of an issue.
to be a controversial topic	A topic that causes disagreement and strong feelings.

Part 2 – Headline Analysis

Activity A: Understand the Headlines

Read the newspaper headlines below. For each one, answer the two questions that follow.

Headline 1:

'Rising energy costs spark widespread concern among UK households'

54. a. Which word means 'cause' or 'trigger'? _____
55. b. Rewrite this headline as a complete sentence using appropriate vocabulary from this lesson.

Headline 2:

'Government calls for reform of social care system'

56. a. What does 'calls for reform' mean? _____

57. b. Use 'It seems to me that...' to give your opinion on this story in one sentence.

Headline 3:

'Climate activists go viral with university campus campaign'

58. a. What does 'go viral' mean in this context? _____

59. b. Is climate change a controversial topic? Write two to three sentences using opinion language from this lesson.

Part 3 – Opinion Language Practice

Activity B: Transform the Sentences

Rewrite each sentence using the expression in brackets. Make any changes necessary to grammar and word order.

60. 1. 'The government is wrong.' [I'd argue that...]

→ _____

61. 2. 'Social media is bad for democracy.' [It seems to me that...]

→ _____

62. 3. 'The policy has positive parts. There are serious problems, too.' [That said, ...]

→ _____

63. 4. 'The issue is very complicated.' [It's a complex issue...]

→ _____

64. 5. 'You make a good argument but I disagree.' [I take your point, but...]

→ _____

Part 4 – Reading and Response

Activity C: Agree, Disagree, or Qualify?

Read each statement below. Write a 2–3 sentence response using language from the vocabulary list. Your response should agree, disagree, or partially agree with the statement.

65. 1. 'Young people today are not interested in politics.'

Your response: _____

66. 2. 'The media is always biased — you can't trust the news.'

Your response: _____

67. 3. 'Social media has had a mostly negative impact on society.'

Your response: _____

Part 5 – Speaking Task: News Debate

Activity D: The Big Issues

Work in groups of three or four. Each person chooses one of the topics below and has 90 seconds to give their view. The rest of the group must ask at least one follow-up question and use at least one expression from Section B.

- The cost of living in the UK
- The role of universities in addressing climate change
- Whether social media companies should be more regulated
- Immigration and its impact on British culture
- Whether it is important to follow the news every day

After each speaker, use the following structure for group response:

- 'I take your point about _____, but I'd argue that...'
- 'To a certain extent I agree, however...'
- 'It's a complex issue — on one hand... on the other hand...'

ANSWER KEY

Activity A: Headline Analysis

Item	Answer
1a	'Spark' means to cause or trigger.
1b	e.g. 'Rising energy costs are causing widespread concern among UK households.'
2a	'Calls for reform' means to demand or request a change in law or policy.
2b	e.g. 'It seems to me that reform of the social care system is long overdue.'
3a	'Go viral' means the campaign spread rapidly online and was seen by many people.
3b	e.g. 'Climate change is certainly a controversial topic. In my view, there is now strong evidence for urgent action. That said, I understand concerns about the economic impact of policy changes.'

Activity B: Transform the Sentences (model answers — accept reasonable variations)

Item	Answer
1	'I'd argue that the government is mistaken in its approach.'
2	'It seems to me that social media may be harmful to democracy.'
3	'The policy has several positive elements. That said, there are serious underlying problems.'
4	'It's a complex issue — there is no simple solution.'
5	'I take your point, but I'm not sure I agree entirely.'

Activity C: Model Responses (sample answers — award marks for appropriate use of vocabulary and reasoning)

Item	Answer
1	e.g. 'I'm not sure I agree entirely. To a certain extent, voter turnout among young people is lower, but there is widespread concern among young people about issues like climate change and housing costs. I'd argue that they engage with politics differently, particularly through social media.'
2	e.g. 'It seems to me that all media has some degree of bias. That said, it would be unfair to say you cannot trust any news. In my view, the best approach is to read widely and compare sources.'
3	e.g. 'It's a complex issue. I'd argue that social media has had both positive and negative impacts. On one hand, it has raised awareness of important issues and connected communities. On the other hand, there is widespread concern about misinformation and mental health impacts.'